

Hindu community events platform — build brief

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What this is, and what is still open

This is a build brief for a web platform serving the UK Hindu community, written to hand to a developer or an agent who will build it. It carries the concept, the research behind it, the feature scope, the money, the technical integrations and the design direction.

Nothing here is fixed, starting with the name. "Utsav" is a working label used in the mock sites so far. It is not registered, not checked for trademark conflicts, and not attached to anything. Treat it as a placeholder and propose better.

The same applies to the business itself. Every element below — the three-tier collection model, the free pricing, the choice of features, the build order, even the decision to serve mandirs rather than devotees directly — is a current best answer rather than a settled one. Several earlier versions of this concept were discarded during research, and this version should be expected to change again when it meets real mandirs and real users. If something here looks wrong, say so rather than building it.

What is *not* open is the handful of constraints in the legal and data section. Those come from UK law and from one well-documented sector failure, and they are the boundaries the product has to work inside.

The business in one paragraph

A free, web-first service that collects Hindu religious and community events from mandirs across the UK into one searchable place, publishes an accurate Hindu calendar computed for UK locations and for the user's own tradition, and lets mandirs post volunteering slots that people can book and have formally recorded. Listings are gathered from what mandirs already publish rather than waiting for them to submit anything, which means the platform launches full rather than empty. It charges nothing in its first phase, by deliberate choice rather than as a trial.

What was tried and discarded

Five ideas from the original concept were tested against research and dropped. They are listed here so nobody rebuilds them.

Discarded	Why	What replaced it
Currency or points for volunteering	Hindu organisations define seva as service given without expectation of reward. Pitching redeemable points to a trustee risks reading as commercialising dharma, from exactly the gatekeepers whose approval the product needs.	Verified hours. A record of seva given, confirmed by a named person at the mandir, in a form DofE assessors and universities accept.
A pure third-party event aggregator fed by mandir submissions	Event discovery is one of the most reliable startup graveyards there is. Y Combinator reportedly had an event-discovery business in nearly every cohort since its beginning without a success, and the structural reason is that organisers only list where users already are.	Collection. Scrape and parse what mandirs already publish, so the database is full on day one and no committee has to type anything.
Ticketing commission as the revenue model	Fees have collapsed. Ticket Tailor charges UK charities from roughly 11p a ticket, TicketSource charges organisers nothing, Zeffy charges nothing at all. A 2.5% + 20p model would be about ten times the going charity rate.	Free listings and bookings; link out to whatever ticketing the mandir already uses.
Gift Aid on event tickets	HMRC is explicit that payments in return for goods or services, including admission, do not qualify. A minimum donation with no real choice does not qualify either.	Nothing on tickets. Gift Aid remains valid on genuinely voluntary sponsorship and annadaan donations, which is a separate flow.

Discarded	Why	What replaced it
Older users as the primary segment	The 2021 census shows only 10% of UK Hindus are over 65, against 18% nationally, while 30% are under 25. The older cohort is both the smallest and the hardest and most expensive to acquire, and WhatsApp already serves them.	Build for the under-25s, who are three times more numerous. Serve older users properly through large type, no-login browsing and printable listings, but do not organise the company around them.

One more was ruled out entirely and is covered in the legal section: selling or licensing user data.

The market

The addressable population is about a million people, heavily concentrated, and much younger than the original concept assumed.

Measure	Figure	Source
Hindus in England and Wales	1.0m, up from 818,000 in 2011	2021 Census
Hindus UK-wide	~1.07m	2021/2022 census rounds
In Greater London	453,000	2021 Census
Aged under 25	30%	2021 Census
Aged under 50	74%	2021 Census
Aged over 65	10%, against 18% nationally	2021 Census
UK mandirs	153 to 312, depending on definition	Curated directories and scraped datasets
Hindu organisations overall	500+, of which 200+ mandirs	Written evidence to a parliamentary committee
Mandirs with a website	~60% (188 of 312 in one dataset)	Scraped dataset

Two consequences matter for the build.

The customer count is the hard ceiling, not the user count. If mandirs are the paying side, there are roughly 200 real prospects in the UK. Winning half of them at £600 a year is £60,000 of recurring revenue. That is a viable small business and not a venture-scale one, which is part of why the current plan is to charge nothing and build reach instead.

Mandir finances vary enormously. One mid-sized Tamil temple trust reported £487,000 income against £425,000 expenditure, with six trustees and eighteen volunteers. The National Council of Hindu Temples itself reported total income of £545 for the year ending March 2025. Any pricing assumption has to survive both ends of that range.

About 40% of mandirs have no website at all, which caps automated collection at roughly 60% coverage. The rest needs Facebook monitoring, community submission and phone calls. This is a real operational cost, not something automation solves.

What already exists

The Hindu-specific room is close to empty. Existing products are almost all India- or US-focused — puja and darshan booking, priest matching, temple websites. In the UK, individual mandirs have built one-off apps (Southampton's Vedic Society, Edinburgh) but there is no platform play.

The instructive comparison is the mosque sector, which is the same country, the same charity structures and the same committee dynamics — and it is crowded. [Masjidbox](#) claims 2,500+ mosques; ConnectMazjid claims 800+ across the USA, Canada, UK and Australia; MOHID, MasjidConnect and MosqueApp compete alongside them. Their marketing describes the identical problem: prayer times on a spreadsheet, events promoted on WhatsApp with no RSVP tracking, donation records in a filing cabinet.

The reason that sector is crowded and ours is not is the single most important finding in this brief. Mosques have a daily utility hook: five prayer times a day, recalculated seasonally, giving a reason to open the app every single day. Installs driven by that hook are what the events and donation modules then monetise. Hinduism has no equivalent daily obligation, so a Hindu events app has nine good nights in October and a very slow rest of the year.

The product's answer to that problem is the calendar, covered below. If the calendar does not create a daily reason to return, the retention case for the whole product is weak and should be revisited before more is built.

On the church side, [ChurchSuite](#) is the UK incumbent at roughly £2 per person per month, built specifically for UK churches with Gift Aid handling and GDPR compliance. Nothing about rotas, hall bookings or donation tracking is denominational, so a mandir could adopt it tomorrow. Assume competent generic competition is always available to the customer.

Who it serves

Two sides, with opposite needs and opposite acquisition costs.

Supply: mandirs and Hindu organisations. Volunteer-run charities, typically with no staff, no marketing function and no one whose job it is to maintain a third-party listing. A committee secretary will not do double data entry for a platform with no users. The product must therefore give them something before asking for anything, and the first ask must take under two minutes. Note that the mandirs with the most need for reach are the small ones, which also have the least capacity to use any software.

Also relevant: the large organisations — BAPS, ISKCON, HSS, Sai groups, NHSF — are competitors for attention rather than suppliers. They have their own channels and their own reasons to keep members inside them. Sampradaya loyalty is strong, and a neutral directory that sends one group's member to another group's event solves a problem they do not have.

Demand: three distinct user types.

1. **Students and young adults, 16–30.** The largest cohort and the cheapest to reach. They want things to go to, and they need documented volunteering for DofE, UCAS and graduate applications. This is the segment the product is built around.
2. **Families and the 30–50 group.** Already well served by WhatsApp groups and committee contacts. They are not the problem to solve, but they are the ones who will forward a listing to a parent.
3. **Older devotees, 65+.** Genuinely underserved, but only 10% of the population and the hardest to acquire directly. Realistically reached *through* their children. The design obligations — large type, no login to browse, printable pages — are owed to them regardless of how few they are.

A fourth group matters for the credential: the institutions that would accept a seva record. Universities with NHSF chapters, DofE assessment centres, and national Hindu charities. They are not users, but their acceptance is what makes the record worth anything.

The proposition, and what the business is actually betting on

To devotees: everything happening at mandirs near you, in one place, free, with no app to install and no account needed to look.

To mandirs: your events are already listed and already reaching people. Claim your entry to correct it, add what we missed, and post seva slots. Free, with no contract.

Beneath that sit three capabilities the business is betting on. Ticketing, payments, listings, QR check-in and the app itself are all commodity — necessary to be credible, worthless as differentiation. These three are not.

1. Access and trust with mandir committees. The sale happens in a committee meeting, partly in Gujarati, at nine on a Tuesday, where someone vouches for you. ChurchSuite could add a Hindu module tomorrow and still lose that room. Not purchasable, and the strongest short-term asset — but it is a relationship rather than a capability, and it caps out at roughly 200 UK customers.

2. Correctly encoded Hindu religious time. The panchang is daily, genuinely needed, and hard — and crucially it is *contested*, so a generic platform will never get it right. It is the answer to the daily-hook problem, it is legible to the trustees whose approval is needed, and unlike the relationships it travels: the same engine serves the US, Canada, Australia and Singapore without modification. This is the piece to build the company around.

3. Being the system of record for participation. Slow to build, valuable once built, and it compounds through a different mechanism from the other two. Relationships do not scale and calendars can eventually be copied, but credentials get *accepted*. If a few universities and DofE centres treat the record as valid evidence, students must use it regardless of how they feel about the product, and mandirs must issue through it because that is what their volunteers ask for.

The strategic reframe worth stating plainly: this is not "an events platform for UK Hindus". It is infrastructure for diaspora Hindu religious life, with the UK as a beachhead because it is compact and accessible. That reframe is what makes a 200-customer home market survivable.

Feature 1 — Events

One page showing what is happening at Hindu mandirs and organisations near you, assembled mostly without anyone at those mandirs doing anything. Listings arrive by three routes of descending quality, and the path between them is the core mechanic.

Tier	Source	Quality	Expected coverage
A — Claimed	Mandir has verified and posts directly	Authoritative, bookable	Small at first, grows
B — Collected	Parsed from the mandir's own website or public pages	Good, needs review	~60% of mandirs

Tier	Source	Quality	Expected coverage
C — Submitted	Community submission or manual entry	Variable, needs review	Fills the gaps

The B-to-A path is the strategic point. A mandir finds a listing with its name already on it, notices something wrong, and clicks *Claim this mandir* to fix it. That inverts the cold-start problem: they are not doing the platform a favour by joining, they are correcting their own entry. This is how Google Business Profile and TripAdvisor bootstrapped supply.

What a devotee sees. Events near a postcode, sorted by date, filterable by mandir, festival, type (aarti, bhajan, katha, garba, class, community), free versus ticketed, and language. Each entry carries what, where, when, cost, who runs it and a link out. Tier A entries are bookable in-page; B and C link to the mandir's own site. No account needed to browse or to book a free event. A printable weekly sheet for noticeboards.

What a mandir sees. Its own listing, claimable with a verification step. A sub-two-minute form to add or correct events. An attendee list for anything bookable, exportable. A confidence indicator on collected entries so they can see what was got wrong.

What building it requires.

- A source register of every UK mandir and Hindu organisation: name, address, postcode, website, social pages, denomination, contact. Seed from public directories and NCHT affiliate lists.
- Per-source collectors. Mandir sites are heterogeneous — WordPress event plugins, hand-written HTML tables, PDF newsletters, JPEG posters, Facebook events. Expect several collector patterns plus per-site overrides.
- An extraction step turning messy text into structured fields. This is the right job for an LLM: it handles "Every Sunday 6pm except during Shravan" far better than regex.
- A human review queue. Nothing collected publishes unseen in the early months.
- Change detection, so updated pages are noticed without re-reading everything nightly.

Legal and etiquette, which matter more than they look. Respect robots.txt, identify the crawler honestly, rate-limit politely. Store and republish *facts* — date, time, place, price — which are not copyrightable. Do not republish descriptive text or poster images; link out instead. Offer one-click removal to any mandir that asks, and publish that policy prominently. Getting this wrong once costs more than the listings are worth.

Open questions. How much manual review per week is sustainable before this becomes a job rather than a product? Do commercial garba promoters get listed, or only mandirs and non-profits? What happens when a collected listing is wrong and someone turns up to a

cancelled event?

Feature 2 — Calendar (Panchang)

An accurate Hindu calendar computed for UK locations and for the user's own tradition. **Build this first.** It needs nobody's permission, it is the answer to the daily-hook problem, and it is the credibility signal that shortens every committee conversation.

What a user sees. Today's tithi, paksha, masa, nakshatra and vara, and whether anything is being observed. Upcoming fasts and festivals with enough notice to prepare — Ekadashi twice monthly, Pradosh, Purnima, Amavasya, Sankashti. Festival pages explaining what it is, when it falls this year in UK time, and what people typically do, with a join to Feature 1 showing which local mandirs are marking it. Pitru Paksha and shraddha dates, which families routinely get wrong. Sunrise and sunset for their postcode, since tithi is reckoned from sunrise. A settings control for region and tradition that changes the answers.

The complexity is the moat. This is not one calendar, and getting the variants right is the entire point:

- **Amanta versus Purnimanta** month reckoning gives different month names for the same day. A Gujarati and a North Indian user see different months for identical tithis.
- **Smarta versus Vaishnava** Ekadashi can fall on different days.
- **Regional systems** — Gujarati, Tamil, Bengali, Marathi, North Indian — diverge on new year, month boundaries and festival dating.
- **Location matters.** Tithi is determined at sunrise, so a festival can fall on different Gregorian days in London and Leicester in edge cases, and routinely differs from India. Most published panchangs online are computed for Indian sunrise.
- **BST and GMT transitions** have to be handled correctly.

What building it requires.

- An astronomical ephemeris (Swiss Ephemeris or equivalent) to compute solar and lunar longitudes. Tithi derives from the angular difference between them.
- Sunrise and sunset computation per location.
- A rules layer mapping tithi, masa and nakshatra to named observances, with variant sets per tradition. This is domain knowledge rather than code, and it is where the real work is.
- **Religious validation.** Compute a full year, print it, have two or three panditjis from different traditions mark it, fix it, repeat. Non-negotiable — a wrong Ekadashi is worse than no calendar at all.
- Plainly written, respectful festival content that does not invent significance.

Open questions. Which tradition ships first? Gujarati/Amanta is the recommendation, matching the largest UK mandir cluster. Should there be a public API? It would let mandirs embed the calendar on their own sites, which is simultaneously a distribution channel, a collection channel and a claim prompt.

Feature 3 — Seva

Mandirs post volunteering slots. People browse and book them like events. Hours are confirmed afterwards by a named person at the mandir, and the volunteer can download a record.

The framing has to be held firmly. Seva is service offered without expectation of return. The product records; it does not reward. No points, no currency, no leaderboards, nothing to redeem. This is not squeamishness — it is the difference between trustees adopting the product and refusing it. What students lack is not motivation but *evidence*: something a DofE assessor, a UCAS statement or a graduate employer will accept.

What a volunteer sees. Open slots near them with role, date, time, number needed, what it involves, and any age or skill requirement. One-tap booking with a calendar file and a reminder. Their own history — where, when, how long, confirmed by whom. A downloadable record, as PDF and as a verifiable link, showing confirmed hours.

What a mandir sees. A form to create an opportunity: role, date and time, slots needed, description, minimum age, contact. A live roster showing which shifts are short — on Thursday, not at seven on Saturday. A one-action confirmation afterwards, which is what turns a booking into a signed-off hour. A button to repeat last year's roster.

What building it requires.

- Opportunity and slot data model with recurrence for regular commitments.
- Booking, cancellation, waitlist, reminders.
- A confirmation step performed by a named, verified mandir account. The signature is the whole value.
- A record format designed to be read by a *third party*: mandir name, charity number, the confirming person's role, and a verification URL.

Safeguarding needs proper advice before launch, not improvisation. Roles involving children or vulnerable adults may require DBS checks. The platform is not the employer, but it facilitates the placement and cannot be indifferent to that. Minimum age is set per role by the mandir. Recommendation for v1: accept volunteers aged 16 and over only, and revisit later. Publish a policy stating clearly that the mandir retains responsibility for supervision, insurance and checks. Take advice from someone who knows charity safeguarding.

Credibility work starts early because it takes a year. In parallel with building, approach one or two universities with active NHSF chapters, a DofE assessment centre, and a national Hindu charity that already tracks sewa hours. Ask what evidence they would actually accept. Their answer defines the record format, so this conversation should happen before the format is finalised.

Open questions. Is the credential valuable enough to pull students in on its own, or does it only work once mandirs are already posting? Who signs off at a mandir with no staff — does the roster need a designated seva coordinator role, and will that person actually do it?